CLONAZEPAM

Controlled drug

Tolerance to anticonvulsant effect

CHEMICAL NAME 5-(2-chlorophenyl)-7-nitro-1,3-dihydro-2H-1,4-benzodiazepin-2-one

CLASS Long-acting benzodiazepine (antiepileptic)

TRADE NAMES Rivotril · Klonopin · Clonex

THERAPEUTIC USES / INDICATIONS

- Epilepsy: myoclonic, absence, atonic seizures; infantile spasms (adjunct).
- Panic disorder.
- Status epilepticus (IV, where available).
- REM sleep behaviour disorder, restless legs (off-label).

ADMINISTRATION

- **PO** tablets or drops; bedtime dose to reduce sedation.
- Increase slowly; taper slowly.

DOSAGES

- **Epilepsy (adult):** start 0.5–1 mg at night, increase gradually; usual 4–8 mg/day in divided doses (max 20 mg).
- **Panic disorder:** 0.25 mg twice daily, up to 1–2 mg/day.
- **Children:** 0.01–0.03 mg/kg/day, titrated (maintenance 0.1–0.2 mg/kg/day).
- **Elderly:** 0.5 mg at night.

PHARMACOKINETICS

- **Onset:** 20–60 min. **Duration:** 6–12 h.
- Metabolised in liver (CYP3A4) — nitro-reduction.
- Excreted in urine. **t½:** 30–40 h.

PHARMACODYNAMICS

- **GABA-A** modulator → anticonvulsant (especially myoclonic), anxiolytic, sedative.

SIDE & ADVERSE EFFECTS

SIDE EFFECTS (COMMON)

- Drowsiness, fatigue.
- Ataxia, dizziness.
- Hypersalivation and bronchial hypersecretion (infants).

ADVERSE EFFECTS (SERIOUS)

- Respiratory depression.
- Dependence; withdrawal seizures.
- Behavioural disturbance, aggression (children).
- Depression, suicidal thoughts.

CONTRAINDICATIONS & CAUTIONS

- Respiratory depression; sleep apnoea.
- Severe hepatic impairment; myasthenia gravis.
- Acute narrow-angle glaucoma.

KEY INTERACTIONS

- **Opioids, alcohol:** CNS depression.
- **Enzyme inducers:** ↓ levels.
- **Valproate:** absence status (rare).

NURSING MANAGEMENT

- Monitor seizures, sedation, secretions in infants.
- Taper slowly.
- Assess mood and behaviour.

PATIENT EDUCATION

- Do not stop suddenly; risk of seizures.
- Avoid alcohol and driving if drowsy.
- Effect on seizures may lessen over time — keep reviews.

KEY POINTS

- Long-acting benzo for myoclonic/absence seizures and panic.
- Tolerance; dependence.
- Start 0.5–1 mg at night.
- Hypersalivation in infants.

SOURCES CHECKED [759] Clonazepam Aristo 0.5 mg Tablets (UK SmPC) [760] Clonazepam, oral (US label) [761] Clonazepam, oral (US label, Coupler LLC)

Full references p. 432–457